

Information Sheet – Exploring Content on Social Media

You are being invited to take part in a new study being run by the Department of Clinical, Educational and Health Psychology, Psychology and Language Sciences at University College London.

We are running a new study to see how our preference for familiar versus new content on social media (e.g., watching videos from your favourite content creator, or searching for a new content) is related to our wellbeing.

If you get involved, we'll ask you to download your data from TikTok and complete some questionnaires. You'll be helping us to find out whether our preferences on social media are related to our wellbeing.

Please read the following information and **if you are happy to take part in the research sessions complete the attached consent form**. Ask one of our researchers if you have any questions:

Researchers: Dr Alex Lloyd (principal investigator), Dr Dan Joinson (postdoctoral researcher)
Emails: alexander.lloyd@ucl.ac.uk, d.joinson@ucl.ac.uk Office Phone: 020 7679 4241

Who is paying for the project?

This study is funded by the Huo Family Foundation as part of their junior faculty grant scheme.

Who has approved the project?

This study has been approved by **UCL Life and Medical Sciences Research Ethics Committee (project ID: 2862)**.

If you wish to make a complaint about the conduct of the study you can contact the Chair of the UCL research ethics committee by emailing: ethics@ucl.ac.uk

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1. What is the project about?

Early adulthood is an exciting but challenging part of life where we experience heightened emotions and feelings. We also live in a digital age where we have access to a range of content on social media that we must navigate. Sometimes, social media content can make us feel positive, like when we watch a funny video. Other times it may make us feel less positive, like if we see upsetting content. We would like to understand how an individual's preference for staying with familiar genres of social media content, versus exploring new social media content is linked to mental health outcomes.

- In this project, we want to find out if your preference to trying new content versus stick with familiar content is related to our wellbeing
- We hope that this project can help us to learn new information about ways in which we can help prevent the development of mental health difficulties in adolescence and early adulthood.

In total, we are asking around 600 young people aged 18-24 to take part in our study. **We will ask you to complete the study once now and again in 6-months time. It is very important that you complete the study the second time as well.**

2. What am I being asked to do?

In the first stage of this study, all you'll be asked to do is complete a short 5-minute guide that shows you how to access and download your TikTok data.

If you complete this, you will be invited to take part in an online task, completing a series of questionnaires. You will complete the same set of questionnaires at both timepoints. We will also ask you to download your TikTok data and upload this to a secure platform at both timepoints. Each session should take a maximum of 1-hour to complete (1-hour now and 1-hour in 6-months time), meaning the entire study will take 2-hours to complete. The topics covered in these sessions include:

- **Wellbeing**
- **Your experiences and thoughts on social media**
- **Emotions and social relationships.**

All questionnaires have successfully been used with young adults in other research studies. These questionnaires are:

- The self-concept clarity
- The motivations for electronic interactions scale
- The Rosenberg self-esteem scale
- The online and offline social sensitivity scale
- The digital activity and feelings inventory
- The online self-disclosure scale
- The bonding and maintained social capital scale
- The off to online scale

- The online self presentation scale
- The emotion regulation questionnaire
- The Generalized Anxiety Disorder-7 Questionnaire
- The Patient Health Questionnaire-8
- The Eating Disorder Examination Questionnaire.

Some of these questionnaires cover topics related to symptoms of depression, anxiety and eating disorders. Some participants may find these sensitive or emotionally uncomfortable. If you are currently experiencing significant emotional distress, or have a current or past mental health or eating disorder condition, you may wish to carefully consider whether you would like to take part. Participation is entirely voluntary, and are you free to skip any questions you do not wish to answer. As your data is anonymous, we cannot provide you with your results from the questionnaires you complete, or give you a formal diagnosis of any health condition.

You will be asked to complete each of these questionnaires twice, once at the start of the study, and also 6-months later. It will last around 1 hour, and you can take part when you want via the online platform you are registered on.

3. Do I have to take part?

No, participation is voluntary. We are happy to answer any questions you may have to help you decide whether to take part, but it is entirely your decision. If you sign up then change your mind, just let us know. If you would rather not complete some parts of the session or answer any particular questions, that is fine. If you decide not to take part, we will respect your wishes. If you decide you do not wish to take part, we will check whether you would like your responses to be removed from the study as well.

4. The research session

The research sessions will involve uploading data from TikTok and some survey questions.

If you agree to take part:

- You can proceed to the next page consent to take part and read more about downloading your data from TikTok.
- You will complete the study on a computer or on your phone.
- You will be paid the amount advertised on the platform as a thank you for taking part.

If you are happy to take part in the research session, please complete the attached consent form.

5. Why do we want to collect this information?

We are interested to see if your individual tendency to stick with familiar content versus searching for new social media content is related to mental health outcomes.

6. What are the benefits of taking part?

During this study, you will learn about how to request your information from TikTok. We will also provide you with opportunities to explore this data yourself, like seeing the number of videos you have watched and engaged with. **6 months later, during the second part of the study, we'll send you more detailed information about the types of videos you watched in TikTok, and your patterns of use.**

We also hope that you are enthusiastic about the opportunity to contribute to important and relevant research exploring how people engage with social media.

7. Are there any risks of taking part?

As previously stated, several of the questionnaires you are asked to complete may be emotionally sensitive or uncomfortable to some participants. Before you are given the opportunity to complete these, we will provide you with a warning and details of places you can find support.

Throughout this entire study, you can contribute as little or as much as you want. The TikTok data we are requesting that you download cannot be linked to your personal account. We are not interested in the exact content you are viewing on TikTok and will only look at how similar or dissimilar these videos are to content you have previously watched. We do not require you to provide us with your TikTok username, and we will not collect this.

Your responses are strictly confidential and if there are any questions you don't want to answer, this will be respected. All researchers have enhanced DBS checks. We have strict safeguarding rules to make sure researchers and participants are safe.

8. What happens to the information we collect?

Your answers are all completely confidential.

- All data is stored in a UCL database.
- We remove your Prolific/BeSample ID from any data that we collect and give you a new ID code instead.
- Your individual results will never be reported.
- You won't be personally identified in any materials produced from this study.
- The findings will be used to write reports for scientific journals and produce learning materials.
- You can ask for your data to be removed at any time during the study and for up to 4 months after the study has ended.
- As your data is anonymous, we are unable to provide feedback on your individual performance throughout the study, or contact you regarding your responses to the questionnaires.
- Your fully **anonymized** data will be deposited in an online database, called the Open Science Framework, that can be accessed by anyone with an internet connection.

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- Other researchers might use this fully anonymous data to carry out studies that explore important questions about young people's wellbeing.

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9. We plan on publishing our findings in an academic, peer-reviewed journal. We may also write a blog post for parents, teachers and young people about our findings. Data Protection Declaration

Data from this study will not be made available to any commercial organisations. Information will be stored securely in accordance with General Data Protection Regulations. Please note however that we have a duty of care to alert relevant authorities of any potential harm to you and/or others. A link to UCL's privacy notice can be [found here](#). The data controller for this project is UCL, and the Data Protection Officer is Alexandra Potts data-protection@ucl.ac.uk. The lawful basis that will be used to process your personal data is: 'public task' and 'research purposes' will be the lawful basis for processing special category data. The special category data we will collect is: Ethnicity, sexual orientation, mental health, gender, date of birth and political views.

10. If you are concerned about how your personal data is being processed, or if you would like to contact us about your rights, please contact UCL in the first instance at data-protection@ucl.ac.uk.

UCL Data protection privacy notice

The Data Protection Officer at University College London makes sure that your personal data is kept safe. They can be contacted at: data-protection@ucl.ac.uk.

*More information about how your data is stored can be found here:
<https://tinyurl.com/2p888vxv>*

Your data will be processed under the lawful basis of 'Public task' for personal data and 'Research purposes' for special category data. Your personal data will be processed so long as it is required for the research project.

We will ensure that remove your name and any identifying information from data, and will try to minimise the processing of personal data wherever possible.

If you are worried about how your personal data is being used, or if you would like to contact us about your rights, please contact UCL first at data-protection@ucl.ac.uk.

11. Helplines and support

Here are some contact details of places where you can find information and mental health support should you feel you need it. We will remind you of these sources of support during the study when asking about sensitive topics, and again at the end of the study.

[please note, this section will be amended for each country to outline the country-specific support we have identified in the ethics application]